Trudge in the Long Night

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The Challenger

COL-307901

The Challenger

210: "A voice came from above and spoke to the man, 'An important thing will happen to you.'"

The lecturer is young and proud, standing like a newly sprouted grapevine growing upright.

210: "What will it be? The man asked."

210: "You will gain wealth, you will gain fame. You will walk in the garden of wisdom and happiness. The voice answered."

210: "Thus, until he died, he spent his life waiting for his fortune, and it never arrived."

The lecturer walks from one side of the square to the other, an unfurled scroll in his hands.

210: The voice from above brought promises—a glimpse of his forthcoming fate.

210: He believed in the promise, and, in doing so, forged his own tragic end.

Thirty-seven: ...

A soft, contented cooing comes from the audience.

Thirty-seven: ... Mhmm ...

Sophia: 37 ... 37 ...

The whisper fails to awaken the sleeping girl.

After hesitating for a moment, Sophia reaches out and gently shakes 37.

Thirty-seven: ... Hmm ... Huh? What's happening ... ?

37 rubs her eyes, lifts her disheveled hair, and looks around in a daze.

Thirty-seven: ... Has 210 finished his speech yet?

Sophia: Not yet, but you were sleeping so soundly just now that you were snoring a bit. I was worried they might hear you ...

Sophia: And ... it doesn't seem polite to sleep during someone else's speech ...

Sophia: Especially for 210, you know how much he enjoys delivering these lectures. He's always so concerned about whether he has the audience's attention ...

Thirty-seven: Surely though it's worse to hinder others from acquiring knowledge like this?

Thirty-seven: Truth should neither rely on such rhetoric nor be so opaque in presentation. I fail to see how there could be any real knowledge in all this flamboyance.

Thirty-seven: *Yawn*, so you see, I'm simply lessening his sins ... At least the rhythm of his speech makes for a fine sleeping aid ...

37 yawns softly and leans against Sophia.

Yet the rhetoric about fate, path, and glory of self-selection continues to pour into their ears.

Thirty-seven: ...

37 opens her eyes once more to see Sophia gazing forward intently beneath her red hair.

Thirty-seven: Are you truly so rapt by this topic?

Sophia: ... I suppose I'm not sure yet.

Sophia: People have always cared about their fate, about what will happen tomorrow and the next day.

Sophia: I don't know my own number yet. I don't understand my essence, let alone fate ...

Sophia's gaze drops to her clasped hands resting in her lap.

Sophia: His lecture does make sense: working hard and striving forward is obviously a good thing.

Sophia: But I feel like I still haven't found my way.

Sophia: I only just arrived here, there's still so much for me to learn ...

Sophia's voice is subdued, fading until finally reaching a whisper.

She takes a deep breath, as if to revitalize her spirit, and lifts her eyes to look at 37.

Sophia: What about you, 37? Aren't you curious at all about your fate?

Sophia: Ah ...

Thirty-seven: ... Mhmm ...

37 breathes out a steady huff.

Thirty-seven: ○ ... is not the greatest prime number ...

Obviously, she needs sleep, and she is especially adept at falling into deep slumbers.

210's impassioned rhetoric is apparently so tedious to her that she can't hold her eyes open even another moment.

210: "When the man lay sick in bed, he cried up to the voice from above, asking, 'When will all that you have promised finally arrive?'"

210: "The voice from above scorned him, saying, 'It has already come and gone, only you never sought it out.'"

210: "So the man lamented his cowardice, his idleness, and all the fortunes he had lost."

210: That's why we should be vigilant about our own fortunes. We must keep our vision clear, listen to our own voice, and not stagnate waiting for the promises of others.

210: If we succumb to cowardice, or complacency, even those gifts promised to us by fate can slip away.

210: Human innovation and knowledge come from courage, a thirst for truth, and constant curiosity.

210: It is for this reason that we must forge our own paths and control our own fates—

He raises his hand high, and the future rhetorician begins to emerge.

As he makes his eloquent speech, a pile of seashells amasses before him, one by one, representing the audience's support.

He is satisfied, but not completely.

210: Fate—yes, and as we're discussing fate, we cannot ignore the fate of those sitting among us.

210: Our star of Hermes, fell upon fate at birth, bringing us hope for enlightenment.

210: We could let her speak, to show her light hasn't diminished, but it seems sleep has taken hold of her, preventing her from shining.

210 turns around and points abruptly to the other side.

210: But fortunately, there are still those among us who can represent the inevitability of fate.

He extends his hand, palm up, fingers forward, in an inviting gesture.

The crowd disperses like startled fish, revealing a young man.

210: Come, Atticus, my friend—he who will receive the "revelation."

210: You are destined to become the perfect number, to receive all the wisdom and all the promises due—our future leader of Apeiron.

210: Don't let silence swallow that light. Please articulate to us your views about fate and share your wisdom.

The young man, given a prestigious title, does not stand out in the crowd. His gaze slides over the inviting hand and rests on an empty spot in the air beside it.

Atticus: This is your speech, not mine, 210.

210: But surely no one understands fate better than you, our perfect "6", awaiting the arrival of your fate every moment, every day.

The young orator holds the moment with anticipation—yes, if anyone deserves to show wisdom comparable to his own it would be his present target.

He greedily seeks the arrival of what he imagines to be an evenly-matched debate.

Atticus: ... I ...

All eyes move to surround Atticus. Accustomed to being invisible in a crowd, he attempts to turn slightly as if to escape the challenge and the weight of their gaze.

Sophia: Hmm, Atticus doesn't seem too happy. What is this "revelation" that 210 is talking about?

Thirty-seven: Oh nothing important. Just a lot of nonsense.

Thirty-seven: All leaders are supposed to receive a special "revelation" when their soul numbers are revealed. It's the sign of a 6's succession to leadership.

Thirty-seven: Like the oracle of Apollo in Delphi.

The commotion must have disturbed her sleep, or perhaps it is the peacocking of the orator that awakens her.

Sophia: It all sounds incredible. Are you saying they can hear the voice of the gods ... ? Or is this something about numbers ... ?

The redhead, still new to the island, seems in awe.

However, 37 thinks it's no big deal.

Thirty-seven: But the leader's number has always been 6, so there's nothing new about this "revelation." We already know the outcome.

Thirty-seven: 210 uses far too many meaningless words. Why not just call him 6?

Sophia: You mean, call Atticus 6? But isn't the current 6 "that person" ...?

Thirty-seven: Oh, yes, Atticus hasn't received the "revelation" yet.

Thirty-seven: But he will be 6 eventually. It's in his destiny.

Atticus: —I don't really know about that.

The young man's voice grows louder, interrupting the distant whispers.

Sophia: ... !

210: How can that be?

210: You are number 6, we all know. You will become number 6 and possess everything a 6 should have—infinite wisdom, supreme vision, a sharp mind, and the poise of a leader.

210: Since you inherited the bloodline of the prophecy, your "revelation" has been predestined since your birth. It's even more clear than a voice from above.

210: See how similar you are to the person in the story. You both heard the prophecy, and you both know your own fates.

210: What did you gain from it? And what did you hear?

It is a bold challenge.

A verbal challenge from the proud peacock to the island's future leader.

210: You didn't throw your seashell; I want to know why, perhaps you can illuminate some of your ever hidden thoughts.

210: My friend, it is through the clashing of minds in a debate that we can gain a deeper understanding of one another. I pray you will share—

"Clack."

210: ...

His speech is interrupted by a crisp clattering sound. He looks down to see a new addition to the seashells at his feet. His hoped-for opponent gently tossed his "challenge" aside along with the shell.

210 cannot read anything other than "humiliation" in the shell.

Atticus: You misunderstand, 210. I have no thoughts on fate ...

Atticus finally meets his gaze.

Atticus: I don't have an answer to your question.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Bottle

COL-307902

A Bottle

That time, we parted on poor terms.

After a long while, I grew taller, the hem of my dress had risen from my ankles to my calves, and Atticus and I brought up that avoided debate again.

Sophia: Atticus, Atticus!

When I found Atticus, he was, as usual, wandering alone on the beach.

I always found him there early in the morning, so if I needed to speak with him, I would come here at the same time.

Atticus: Good morning, Sophia.

He was bringing a stranded fish back into the sea, as it flashed from his hands he gave me a smile.

Sophia: Good morning.

Of all the people on the Island, Atticus was the one I could communicate with the easiest.

It wasn't anyone else's fault—Apeiron operated on its own set of rules to maintain stability. It was always going to be difficult for an outsider to break into their tight-knit community.

But my visits to the beach were not just to see him.

Atticus: Are you here to collect your sand again today?

Sophia: Yes. The fine sand here is ideal for polishing lenses. My father's eyeglasses are just about ready.

Sophia: His eyesight has been deteriorating more and more. I hope these will help.

Sophia: ...

Maybe it's because of my father's health, I feel more upset and sensitive than usual.

This is not a good time to confide.

Sophia: This morning, he woke up and asked me why it was still dark. Hadn't the day arrived yet?

Sophia: I worry, worry that the glasses won't keep up with his decline, or perhaps that they were never going to help him ...

Atticus: Hmm ...

Atticus: And yet, you still made them.

Sophia: ... ?

I'm pretty sure it is a declarative sentence, yet I sense his confusion inside—more confusion than in any question.

But I'm not always right, especially on this island. So, perhaps I'm imagining things.

Sophia: ...

Atticus: ...

I stop speaking, knowing that sharing my worries over my father will do nothing to lessen them. The sea breeze blows over us. Each seagull's cry is distinct and loud.

Sophia: ...

In the school, such unusual quietness often causes an uneasy feeling in my heart—anxiety.

But now, despite the silence between us, my breathing is even. This peace of the moment feels comforting.

Atticus: ...

Time passes in hours as the sunlight reaches overhead near its zenith. At last, Atticus stands up.

Sophia: Are you leaving?

Atticus: Yes, it's nearly lunchtime.

Sophia: ... Huh? But it's still early yet? Are you hungry?

Atticus: ... No.

He shakes his head slightly, a bit uneasy.

Atticus: I need to go early, or there won't be any quiet spots left.

I realize now why I rarely encounter him on the other routes I walk.

Sophia: Why don't you sit with us?

Sophia: ... Is it because of 210?

I ask softly, then immediately regret it, realizing that my inappropriate question would only cause awkwardness.

Sophia: ... Oh, sorry, I didn't mean to ...

Panic occupies my mind, and I struggle to come up with a suitable excuse.

Atticus: No.

Atticus's response surprises me. He gently shakes his head.

Atticus: I'm not specifically trying to avoid him.

As if sensing my guilt, he smiles.

Atticus: Before 210 was 210, he didn't look kindly on me—of course, that has to do with his competitive nature, which I never minded.

Atticus: Then he became 210—a number easily factored ... And well everything that came next feels terribly predictable.

He looks down at the sand, then lifts his head again.

Atticus: I know why you asked, Sophia. Please don't take it too hard. That speech was just a trigger ... Our interactions have always been like this.

Sophia: Hmm ...

I try to remember the debate that came out of nowhere.

Sophia: I don't quite understand ...

Sophia: When I first arrived here, you took such excellent care of me.

Sophia: And you, 210, and 37 grew up together as friends ...

Sophia: But then ... after your debate with him ...

Atticus: ...

Atticus: I was young then and I was flippant in my behavior—I provoked him, given his character, I knew he would take it as a humiliation.

Atticus: It was my decision, so I must accept the consequences of it.

Atticus: But that wasn't a debate, Sophia. He didn't want my point of view.

Atticus's voice and manner are as calm and cool as the sea breeze.

His description of his conflict with 210 feels more like it came from a distant observer.

Atticus: I know him, and I know myself. We think differently.

Atticus: He is not in need of an exchange of ideas.

Atticus: In fact, he's not at all interested in what I think. He just wants a victory.

Sophia: ... He is competitive.

His tone remains even, almost emotionless.

Atticus: An exchange of ideas like that is purposeless. Each side will stick to their own opinions, vainly trapped in position. In the end, there is no mutual understanding. It only further reinforces their own defenses.

He sighs, the confusion surfacing again.

Atticus: I've tried and tried, but people always step into the same river over and over again.

Atticus: Facing this inevitable end, any action at all seems futile.

Sophia: ...

I'm not sure what to say; his words hold merit—but I, I somehow feel ...

Sophia: I ...

Before I can utter another word, Atticus asks me a pointed question.

Atticus: Sophia, you're smart. You know enough about your father's health.

Atticus: You also know those glasses won't be of much help to him.

Atticus: ... Why do you choose to struggle so much against the path of fate?

It's an offensive question, and I feel at first I should be uncomfortable with it.

But I know it's different with Atticus. His confusion is genuine, not mocking or cruel.

Sophia: ...

I rarely have the opportunity to mentor others on this island. The whole thing is unfamiliar to me.

Sophia: ... I don't know.

I regret my response. It is too hasty, too dismissive.

In fact, I have the real reason clear in my mind.

When my mother was dying of her illness, I felt so powerless. I know I don't want to experience that a second time.

Sophia: ... I have to do something, anything.

I take a deep breath, trying to gather my scattered thoughts.

Sophia: You're right, Atticus. Even with effort, we can't avoid the inevitable.

Sophia: But I think, we can't just sit around and do nothing about it ...

Atticus: ... ?

The inquisition in his eyes is piercing. I feel suddenly I have to explain it in their way.

Sophia: Preparing for the inevitable is like ... preparing a psalm for a morning class.

Sophia: Practicing and familiarizing oneself with upcoming difficulties makes it easier to face them ...

I feel I don't often, or rather, I lack the time to really consider meaning.

Sometimes, the quality that allows us to face our fate isn't necessarily courage—it might just be the fear of the truth.

Perhaps I'm destined to forget that lengthy psalm. Perhaps there's nothing I can do for my father ...

Sophia: ... But preparing for what must come is better than doing nothing at all.

But giving hope to others must be done in the name of "courage," if nothing else.

Sophia: If a glass bottle on the table is destined to fall, I would put a cloth on the floor around it. So even if the bottle does break, the mess will be easier to clean.

Atticus: ...

I turn to look at Atticus. He's frowning, as if pondering my words.

Sophia: Atticus, you don't actually want to answer that question, do you?

I speculate on his thoughts, and this is also offensive.

Sophia: I've heard from 37 and others in the school about this "revelation" ... I don't understand what it is exactly, but they say it's a gift of fate.

Just like that voice from above, the "revelation" promises all the wisdom of the world to the 6s of each generation.

Sophia: But ...

I try to express everything I feel.

Sophia: Do you fear it?

Atticus: ...

Atticus: I don't know.

His voice is so faint that the words almost feel illusory, like a false memory, then it begins to roar.

Atticus: If this gift is from the above, and it never asks for your own desires or cares about your existence, can it still be called a "gift"?

Atticus: ––Do we really have no choice but to kneel before destiny, begging for its love and mercy?

Atticus's hand trembles slightly.

I'm surprised by the rage and intensity in his voice. I've never seen him so upset.

The people of the island are generally reserved due to their intelligence. 210 is an outlier, but Atticus's words are still sharper.

Maybe this is the perspective he held back from that debate.

Atticus: So I turn away from the table. I don't want to see whether the bottle is teetering.

Atticus finally looks at the fine sand in my hand.

Atticus: But I think you're right.

I only remember that at the end of our conversation, he came towards me with a kind of expression on his face.

That expression was like a smile, yet also like sorrow or perhaps relief—a face filled with determination.

Atticus: Thank you for telling me all this, Sophia.

Sophia: And thank you for listening to me, Atticus.

We said goodbye as we did countless times before, not affectionately, but also not quite distantly.

I returned downhill to my home to continue making the lenses, lenses I knew would never be of any use to my father.

He went uphill to his home, back to the brilliance of the current "6" in her supreme wisdom.

Sophia: ...

Sophia: Goodbye!

I don't know why I said goodbye to Atticus.

Atticus: ...

He turned back, nodding his head in acknowledgment.

After that, I have never seen Atticus walking on the beach again.

He began his long retreat.

TO BE CONTINUED...

An Oyster Shell

COL-307903

An Oyster Shell

Believer: It's time for us to go.

I took a deep breath and adjusted the grapevine on my head, trying to make it look as symmetrical as possible.

In my youth, the third weekend of each month with an even-numbered date was the happiest for me.

210: Let's go, I'm ready.

It was a day of speculation when the 6's coordinator invited the island's finest youths to talks.

They would not overlook me, just as a girl collecting shells on the beach wouldn't miss a pearlescent oyster.

Believer: ... Hm?

The usually bustling square is deserted, and I, along with a few other students, pause outside.

Believer: One moment, let me inquire about the situation.

Thirty-seven: ... Haah.

210: It seems our Star of Hermes is in need of some sleep. You ought to keep an eye on the time; that's a number as well.

210: At least, time is counted in numbers. You like numbers.

Thirty-seven: I can see everyone's number, but I never said I liked all numbers.

210: I hope you aren't about to say you dislike 210.

Thirty-seven: Hah ...

Thirty-seven: Irrelevant to my likes and dislikes, 210 is simply a poor number.

Thirty-seven: It has four prime factors yet lacks a solid base, so it's prone to deformation like a rhombus.

210: Well, it is no surprise. We know prime numbers are born unique, standing like the cornerstones of all others. Composite numbers are slightly inferior, like frivolous and fast-decaying paintings.

Thirty-seven: Why bring up all the prime numbers and composites numbers? We're just talking about 210.

Thirty-seven: I don't understand your methodology.

Thirty-seven: And I don't understand why you always call me the Star of Hermes. Is it because Hermes is the Thrice-Greatest and he has his Seven Hermetic Principles?

Thirty-seven: I am 37, not 3 and 7. They are not the same conceptually. You shouldn't make such a fundamental mistake in your understanding of numbers.

It is hardly a pleasant chat. My relationship with 37 has never been harmonious.

But we've grown accustomed to this bantering tete-a-tete, always attacking each other. That's just how we interact.

The familiarity of it all breeds contempt. As we walk down the same old paths, arguing over things we've debated hundreds of times.

But it is on these familiar paths that a moment of boldness can make the most change.

Believer: I'm sorry, you two might have to wait a little longer.

Believer: 6 isn't ready for you yet, but she won't need much time. You can follow me to the gazebo under the grapevines to sit in the shade and wait for your meeting.

Thirty-seven: Her first time being late in all these years.

37 follows 6's coordinator, moving at pace towards the vine-draped gazebo.

Meanwhile my steps are hesitant, my thoughts have become a mess.

210: Is our leader ill?

The unease from the anomaly spreads in my mind. Everyone on the island knows that the leader's health is in irreversible decline.

Excellence often invites the envy of fate.

The lifespan of each 6 has been lamentably short. Atticus's mother, the previous 6, left this world when he was still young.

Then, the current 6 received the "revelation," becoming the new leader of the school—and, of course, in my opinion, the finest leader.

6, perfect, balanced, and harmonious. She explores the form of Forms and traverses the hidden figures of the universe.

One night I wondered, how many more times would I be able to converse with her?

So filled with wisdom, unique understanding, bold hypotheses, and the courage to seek out the new and novel and not be complacent.

She deserves all her respect and adoration.

210: Maybe we can go back and visit her again when she's feeling better.

210: I'm willing to make time for this discussion, whenever it may be.

Emotions lead to rashness, and rationality is associated with calmness.

I have ignored the coordinator's expression, his lips mumbling like the tide coming in and out on the shore.

Believer: No, it's not because of that.

Believer: You two rest here. When it's time for the meeting, I'll let you know.

Thirty-seven: Alright, I suppose I can take a stroll here while we wait—

Thirty-seven: What a pity ... it's not in season yet. If it were, we could have picked some grapes to eat.

210: ...

210: 37, did you hear something?

Thirty-seven: Hm?

Thirty-seven: Hm, yeah, I heard something too, but it was vague and muffled—

Thirty-seven: I think it's over there, deeper in the grapevines.

The Star of Hermes, so quick to act upon her thoughts.

I follow her, stepping deeper into the vine-laden arbor. Until we find a door left ajar.

An unintentional but fortuitous encounter.

Thirty-seven: It is Atticus. I haven't seen him in so long!

She spots our childhood friend, his pale face obscured beneath a mop of light blonde hair.

Thirty-seven: 6 is talking to Atticus. I heard Atticus hardly comes out during his retreat, unlike 6, who does so every other week.

Thirty-seven: Now you don't have to worry about 6. She may look pale, but at least she has the strength to talk.

Thirty-seven: She's just delayed a bit because she is talking with Atticus.

Despite 37's words, it's clear 6's health is more fragile than before. Her face is paler than Atticus's, and her voice is faint, merging into the air like gentle rain into water.

I can see her lips moving, but I can't hear her voice.

She reaches out a hand, weakly grasping the hem of Atticus's shirt, and pulls back.

Atticus: Hm.

6s all have similar appearances, with their talents depending on hereditary blood—blonde hair, slender figures, pale skin, and wizened eyes.

They're like idols carved from the same mold, perfect reflections of a flawless lineage.

Six: ——, ————, — ...

210: ...

She leans forward, a posture not easy for her in her current state.

Our friend, Atticus, remains standing upright, his eyes looking into space, as if indifferent and utterly devoid of respect.

Atticus: ...

I'm not sure if there's fear in those eyes, but I'm certain of the anger echoing in my chest in reaction to this rude silence. It is an irritation not easily soothed.

Disregard—It is the greatest disrespect and insult, a taste like bad wine. I've tasted it before, and, coincidentally, that bad wine was also a "gift" from this very same cold "statue" that stands before me.

I could forgive his rudeness towards me—but he shouldn't treat 6 this way.

6 has always selflessly guided us in the pursuit of Truth, setting us straight when the path forward is not clear.

On top of that, she is Atticus's aunt. After the previous 6 returned to the Truth, she took over, caring for Atticus as a mother would.

Thirty-seven: Um ...

That "sculpted" young hand, covering the slightly wrinkled one, pulls the hem free.

So disrespectful, so rude.

Atticus draws away and steps through the narrow door. The gaze from his kin follows him in silence until it is cut off by the door panel.

Atticus: You ... what are you doing here?

Surprise flickers across his face. He looks strangely tired.

210: We have more right to be here than you. It's the third weekend of the month and an even date.

Atticus: ... I see.

He nods absently, intending to leave without another word.

210: Stop.

He shouldn't be allowed to just slip away without any criticism.

Atticus: ... ?

My anger is more than justified. He shouldn't have done that to her.

To treat the island's leader this way, a wise person, his own kin, an elder in failing health—

How could he do this?

How?

210: I'm curious, do you even have any self-awareness?

Atticus: ... What do you mean?

210: I think my question is clear enough.

I meet Atticus's gaze, more than satisfied that I've finally broken his calm.

210: Atticus, my friend, everyone on this island knows that you were born a 6 and are destined to become the leader of Apeiron.

210: —Destined to receive the "revelation".

Atticus: ...

210: Do you even understand the weight of this blessing?

Atticus: 210, I don't have time for your debate.

210: This isn't a debate; I'm trying to offer you some help.

I have narrowed in on him, no more room for him to evade me.

210: A mission bestowed from the heavens ... You'll receive the great number, and become the mediator between excess and deficit.

210: The amalgamation of knowledge and wisdom of every 6 since the inception of Apeiron will, without any arduous drilling, enter your mind the moment you receive your number. You will make a great leap.

Atticus: ... Do you think I need you to explain the concept to me?

210: Oh, it certainly felt like it.

I snort out a laugh like a true victor.

Atticus is different today. His usual evasiveness is gone—replaced by anxiety.

This suits me. I try to seize on that gap, like prying open an oyster to expose its insides to the sea air.

Now, looking back at that moment, I can't deny that I lost control.

But it wasn't a day to be defeated, least of all by him.

210: So, should I point out your attitude towards 6?

210: She's weaker than before. You shouldn't treat her like this.

Atticus: Cut out your d**n rhetoric. What are you trying to say?

Hear that? The oyster shell has cracked.

What a great day to be favored by the truth. This is simply too easy.

210: Your disrespect towards her ...

210: She is a 6, one who possesses wisdom, balance, and wholeness. As a fine leader, she manages everything on the island with great efficiency.

210: She cares for the children, connects with the public, and treats you as her own. She has taken on all the duties of your late mother.

210: She is intelligent, courageous, and shares willingly with everyone.

210: She's a role model for 6s; as for you, Atticus—

210: You don't deserve the "revelation". You lack the willingness to share knowledge and the talent to lead, and you haven't and you won't fulfill your obligations.

210: You cannot bear this blessing. You are unworthy of it.

Atticus: ...

He suddenly falls silent.

Atticus: So you think the "revelation" is a blessing?

210: ... ?

I didn't expect him to focus his sights on a mere turn of phrase.

210: Of course—we seek the truth, and the truth lies in wisdom. It's not just me; all the brothers and sisters of Apeiron think like this!

210: That's why we respect 6—

He remains standing upright, but I notice his shoulders drooping slightly … as if some invisible weight presses upon them.

Atticus: The revelation is a curse, my friend.

Aziz hangs his head, I almost read it like nodding, as if he's nodding to himself.

This isn't what I want at all. My oyster has shriveled into a pebble.

Atticus: You're right.

Atticus: She's perfect, she's 6.

Atticus: A complete number, a perfect person, and an outstanding leader.

Atticus: 6s are always like that.

He turns away, sidestepping my obstructing arm, and walks towards the exit, where light streams from beyond the grapevine arbor.

TO BE CONTINUED…

A Demonstration

COL-307904

A Demonstration

Thirty-seven: Ha-ha~

Thirty-seven: This new dish tastes wonderful. Why has no one thought of putting fruit in sour yogurt before?

Sophia: I'm glad you like it. I learned the combination before coming to this island.

Thirty-seven: If you ask me, the flavor tastes just like 143.

Thirty-seven: 11 and 13 are both good numbers, and together they factor into another excellent number!

It was an ordinary day in all respects. Sophia and I grabbed some food and lounged by the gazebo in the square.

210: Nice, another compliment true to your style.

Thirty-seven: Oh—I didn't realize you were here too.

Of course, so did 210.

Thirty-seven: Keep your head down, 210.

210: Please, this is hardly an appropriate time, 37.

210: …

Although I think the number 210 is significantly overestimated by the public, I wouldn't hate a walking grapevine stand.

Thirty-seven: Heh heh. It's been a while since I ate the grapes on your head. They're still so sweet.

Thirty-seven: I'm thinking of grabbing a few more to try them in this yogurt—

210: Please, 37, we're not kids anymore.

210: No more leaping up to snatch grapes from my head like old times! It's undignified!

Thirty-seven: Oh, don't be like that.

I like grapes and other fruits. I like their blend of tart and sweet flavors.

Thirty-seven: Carrying around grapes is one of your few endearing qualities. Don't downplay it.

Sophia: ... Ha-ha.

Thirty-seven: Sophia? Why are you smiling?

Sophia: Oh, nothing, just feeling nostalgic. It's been ages since we've all been together for a meal like this. It reminds me of when we were younger.

Sophia: Back then, we had fewer responsibilities and more time to just be together.

Sophia: We'd meet up for meals now and then and even head to the beach for some fun.

210: As I recall it was that gift that first brought the four of us together.

Sophia: Right, the gift I gave to Atticus.

Sophia: I was new to the island then, and Atticus had been so helpful to me. So, I decided to make him a hat out of Anatolian fabric.

210: "It's because his hair has gotten so long, always falling over his eyes and getting in the way of his reading."

210: Our Star of Hermes gave us a great suggestion.

It's only when we look back that we realize how far we've come.

Talking about the past brings us some joy.

Thirty-seven: A scarf or hat is too plain, it fades over time and lacks geometric beauty—

Thirty-seven: We should give him a diadem headpiece, a sturdy and slender one. That way, it won't be too hot in the summer or get damp in the rainy season.

Stretching out my hands, I make a fitting triangular shape with the index fingers and thumbs of both hands.

Thirty-seven: And equilateral triangles are the best shape! It would make a unique gift!

Thirty-seven: It's just a pity ... that the plan fell through ...

210: That's why I always say Atticus should thank me.

210 has begun to eat the grapes draping from his head as well, a sure sign that he's beginning to relax.

210: It was me who met you in front of the blacksmith's shop and reshaped the crown into a more angular circle.

210: Otherwise, he'd always hurt himself when he bumped into things.

Thirty-seven: No, not at all.

Thirty-seven: Comfort is pointless. The essential beauty of mathematics is far more important, like the clothes we wear!

Sophia: Regardless, he accepted my gift, and the crown indeed helped keep his hair in place.

Sophia: Maybe I can volunteer to deliver Atticus's meal today, bring him some fruit and yogurt, and have a chat with him.

Thirty-seven: Not today.

After finishing my fruit and yogurt, I have other things I must do.

I have planned it all out and set the time earlier.

Thirty-seven: That task has already been assigned to me today.

This is my first time on meal delivery duty.

Most of the time, I'm preoccupied with much more demanding tasks. It required me to spend some time explaining my reasons.

Thirty-seven: 6!

Atticus: 37 ... ?

He must be surprised by my arrival.

As surprised as when he first heard me call him 6 instead of Atticus.

Thirty-seven: I have something I want to talk to you about; you can eat while listening.

I cross the porch and then stoop to pass through the low inner door.

His retreat room is dim, cramped, and completely windowless. The floor is littered with books, some open, some closed.

Placing the meal on the small table, I sit down across from Atticus.

Thirty-seven: This is fruit with sour yogurt, a combination Sophia learned from the outside. It tastes very much like 143, in the best way.

Atticus: ... Thank you.

I scan the book 6 is reading; Euclid's "Elements", nothing more than a basic primer in our school.

A small hill of books lies beside him, their edges showing signs of having been turned. He must have read them all.

Atticus: But why are you here? It's not your job to deliver meals to those in retreat.

Atticus: Is there something you need from me?

He ponders, and seems to answer his own question wordlessly.

He seems different from usual.

Thirty-seven: I'm not good at debates outside of proofs, but you've always been so smart and precise. 210's reasoning is too absurd and flowery, and Sophia's answers feel too mild.

Thirty-seven: 6 is just right to answer such questions. The bigger 6 lacks spare time, always talking about the ship, too busy to even stop for a moment.

Thirty-seven: So, I came to you—the smaller 6, as opposed to the bigger 6.

Atticus seems to have finally gotten used to me calling him 6.

But many people on the island still call him Atticus. They say there can't be two 6s on the island at the same time.

Atticus: She will make time for you. She values you all ... and she is better at exploring these kinds of issues.

Thirty-seven: You're just not one for talking, it's not that you're bad at thinking.

Atticus: She is the current 6.

Thirty-seven: It makes no difference to me. She is a 6, and so are you. You are the same in essence.

My questions are ready, but the path forward isn't smooth. This is a common occurrence in calculations, but I won't be discouraged by it.

If one path is blocked, take a detour; if all paths are blocked, climb through the bushes.

Bushes and walls of books aren't all that different; I know how to climb past them to reach my destination.

Thirty-seven: 26 thinks I shouldn't overlook the process of proof.

Thirty-seven: I know that. My mother taught me the same. Steps should be imprinted on paper and actualized to give more meaning to the results.

Thirty-seven: But 26 believes that even proof leading to a wrong result should be documented. To me that seems ... inexplicable!

Thirty-seven: Everyone knows that the result of a proof is what matters most. A proof that's wrong shouldn't even exist from the start. Like your "Elements," it wouldn't include false theorems.

Thirty-seven: I think he's wasting time. Focusing on such trivialities only distracts from our judgment of true essence.

Thirty-seven: But I can't decide whether I am right or wrong. I need your help.

He closes "Elements" and turns towards me.

I suddenly realize it's been a long time since we last met. His blue eyes are becoming more like those of 6. Yes, as they should. 6s are the same in essence.

Atticus: You mean 26, the sincere man who, in his youth, led the children of Apeiron in their training, including you and me.

Atticus: 37, why do you need to know the right or wrong in this?

Thirty-seven: What kind of question is that? Everything ought to have an answer; I just want to know it! That's all.

He smiles and shakes his head.

Atticus: Words kill the essence. I think 26 just wanted to keep a record of your trials and errors to inform future seekers. He's always valued the passing down of knowledge, and you were always the trailblazer.

Atticus: He's sincere but also clumsy. He probably quickly forgot his original purpose when it came to you.

Atticus: Perhaps you both lost sight of each other's motives in the argument. Did you quarrel?

Thirty-seven: ... Hmm.

6 is right. It wasn't a pleasant debate between 26 and me. Since Sophia's arrival, I've not seen anyone give me that kind of look.

Thirty-seven: Alright, I understand about 26's mindset. But I still want to know, is there any value in a proof with a conclusion that turns out to be wrong?

Occasionally, such questions would cause 6 to ponder briefly, but now, his response is swift.

Looks like I'm in luck.

Atticus: 37, value is relative.

Thirty-seven: Well it shouldn't be! People ought to only value a proof because it's correct!

Thirty-seven: If there's no measure for judgment, why do we distinguish right from wrong at all?

Atticus: ...

I actually don't care about the answer to this question. It's irrelevant to mathematics.

But debates over definitions are always my weakness. Though I'm convinced that I'm right, I fail to convince others.

Numbers are solid and reliable, while language is vague and unclear. People argue endlessly over rhetoric and semantics, shifting focus away from the essence of things.

6 is the best of us at these questions. He always finds a fable that makes things simple and understandable.

I wait for 6 to tell me a fable so that the next time I get into a debate, I can come up with a perfect example.

Atticus: I'm sorry, 37 ...

Atticus: I can't help you with that right now.

6 shifts his gaze away, turns a page, and adjusts the angle of the crown pressing on his head.

It looks like it would make a fine paperweight—the metallic triangle is certainly more ideal than fabric in that role.

Thirty-seven: I can wait for you to finish your page.

Atticus: No ... it's not about the page. I truly don't know how to answer your question.

Atticus: Or maybe I'm searching for that answer too.

I watch him close the book, sliding it back into the mountain of others.

Thirty-seven: So when you're done reading all these books, will you have the answer?

Atticus: ...

Atticus: I don't know.

Atticus: But it's better to try something than to do nothing at all.

Thirty-seven: Hmm ... ?

That doesn't sound like his usual style. And I feel like I've heard it somewhere else.

He really has changed. It's strange; can appearances change so noticeably while the essence remains the same?

There must be a key to this.

Thirty-seven: So ... Is this a proof you have to give?

Thirty-seven: One that requires a room full of books and a long retreat—the ultimate proof?

Thirty-seven: Then you should've told me earlier. I don't want to be taken by Abraxas, and be tied to a rock to have my eyes pecked out by vultures!

Atticus: ...

Atticus: No, it's not that serious. I'm just contemplating the nature of "6".

Atticus: ... Maybe this is indeed a proof, one about my own number.

Thirty-seven: Hm? But you already know the answer. What's there left to prove?

6's answer seems to wait on a breath. He flips through the book with a faint smile.

Atticus: ... In that lies a whole other question entirely, 37.

Atticus: Does a proof with a correct conclusion have any value?

In that single phrase 6 has utterly bewildered me.

I am 37, he is 6, right from birth. Neither of us ever proved our numbers, but we simply know the answer to be right.

It's enough; the essence cannot change. So why would 6 ask such a question?

It's a needless worry, a waste of effort.

But I suddenly feel I shouldn't disturb him anymore.

The work of a proof mustn't be interrupted or hindered; that's a rule everyone knows.

He escorts me to the door of his retreat room, and I stoop again to pass through the low inner door.

This door, obstructing vision as well as movement, makes it feel more like a cave than a doorway. It makes the retreat seem even more sealed off.

Thirty-seven: Hey—okay, I'm out!

I can't clearly recall how I bid farewell to 6 or whether he cautioned me to watch my step. I know I didn't get a straight answer from him; only another question was tacked on—one that left me confused and a little dizzy.

Fortunately, just as I leave the cave and feel the night sea breeze, a solution that I had disregarded earlier comes back to me. A perfectly timed epiphany.

I hurry home to write it down.

On the way, I cross paths with Sophia again, she expresses some concern for 6 and asks me about him.

Does he read a lot? Is he still in good health? Is he working on a proof? What kind of proof is it?

He's read many books, as many as a small mountain.

His health is fine. He eats well and breathes evenly.

I know nothing of his proof—but in any case, it seems to be a proof about himself.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Book for Children

COL-307905

The Book for Children

Proof requires time.

Atticus still hasn't fully gotten his own answer.

Atticus: "A voice from the above spoke to a man, 'An important thing will happen to you.'"

Outside his retreat room, people are chopping down trees from the forest, slicing the wood into planks, and then fashioning sticks and joints from the planks.

The outline of the ship has already taken shape.

Atticus: Thus, he spends his life waiting for a miracle.

Atticus: Until death arrives, and nothing has happened.

A ship signifies the start of a journey. It carries people and goods across waters ... it discovers new worlds.

People call out, communicating with one another, choosing a direction.

Atticus: "When the man lay sick in bed, he cried up to the voice from above, asking, 'When will all that you have promised finally arrive?'"

Pushing, pushing, and then more pushing. Clear grooves are left in the sand.

Atticus: ...

Atticus: Please come in.

A figure appears at the entrance of the retreat room. He walks over to the desk and places down a dinner tray, but does not sit down.

210: It's strange that you actually feel like talking.

They are not on friendly terms, with 210's attitude resembling a bristled tomcat.

Atticus lowers his head and flips through the pages, then uses his crown to hold down the book before looking up at him.

Atticus: This has nothing to do with my personal feelings. You must have something to say since you came here specifically.

Atticus: That being the case, you might as well just ask.

210: The ship has already set sail.

210: Many people are on that ship, people we know, people who watched us grow up.

210: The cook, the accountant, the errata operator ... Sophia's father, and 6 ... they're all on the ship.

For a small island that has so far managed to avoid the Emanation, exploring into the storm undoubtedly requires immense courage.

This is destined to be a great journey where people confirm and reconfirm their hypotheses, staking their lives for the opportunity to discover new horizons and search for the truth.

Atticus: Sophia already told me that the ship was completed.

The windowless and narrow-doored retreat is cut off from the outside world. And it seems this fervent exploration movement hasn't affected any of Atticus's plans.

He never stepped out to see the new beginnings, as if the island's achievements had nothing to do with him.

Piles of books have been shifted around, spreading outward, while new books are placed closer to his inner circle, like ripples from a droplet of water on the surface of a lake.

210: Aren't you going to see them off?

Atticus: I am still in retreat.

210: You never intend to fulfill your duties.

210: Perhaps it's the predetermination of fate that sets you apart, or maybe it's the brilliance of another 6 that makes you feel so inferior.

The accumulated resentment between them further sharpens his words.

The young man has followed his aspirations, which developed reverence, and then he comes into contact with envy – resignation, suspicion, and resentment.

He starts to question himself and, silently, fate itself.

210: I can't help but wonder if you are truly capable of doing the job of a 6.

Atticus: Your respect for 6 ... I mean Alma, has blinded you.

Atticus: Your questioning doesn't come from the heart. Emotions are clouding your judgment.

The pages of the book turn to a new chapter, and a familiar fable jumps out—

Atticus: 6 is only a number.

Atticus: You should listen more to what 37 says, "the number is significantly overestimated by the public."

—A fable that tells a familiar story. This is the third time Atticus has read it today.

Atticus: ... This topic should end now. You've delivered your message; now we should get back to our respective work.

Atticus: "Go back, 210. I don't want to argue with you."

That crown of his is infuriating.

210: My friend, what book are you reading? What kind of work has touched your heart, making you so obsessed with it that you neglect friends and family?

His actions contradict his modest tone. He reaches out and decisively pulls out the book that has been the subject of this undue attention.

210's breathing becomes deep and slow, his heart bubbling like a flatbread on a stove.

It's a picture book, The Voice From Above. It's so familiar, so ordinary. Every child on the island has heard this story at some point or another.

210: Is this what you've been busy with ... reading these, these children's books?

Atticus: Not only those, but indeed them as well.

Atticus speaks calmly, as if stating something that is a matter of course.

210: A ... children's fable ... ?

In anger, 210 leans forward, clenches his fist, and presses it on the table.

210: It seems the "curse" of being 6 has driven you mad. The wisdom and talent destined for you have given you the audacity to squander them.

210: Yet, no matter what, you will become a 6, and you will receive all the gifts that come with that crown!

210: You value your kin less than a children's fable. You see your friendly neighbors as vague "others" ...

210: A blessing bestowed upon the least deserving person—

210's voice chokes in his throat, then, with a snort, sizzles out like a flame in water.

210: Your head lacks wisdom, and your heart lacks compassion.

He stands straight, palms covering his eyes, hiding his expression.

210: I can see that you'll be the reason why we stagnate in seeking the truth!

Atticus: Progress is relative.

Atticus lifts his head from the book, and his blue eyes are widened.

Atticus: Is it then? Well, let me ask you, my friend. If the wisdom we seek leads us to our own destruction, what would you choose?

210: ... What do you mean?

210: Are you suggesting that our decision to explore beyond the island is wrong?!

Atticus: I didn't mean that ...

The misalignment in the conversation leads to misunderstanding, and 210's anger almost becomes tangible and touchable.

Atticus: I'm just thinking ... no, forget I said anything.

Their resentment towards one another boils past reconciliation.

210: ... Fine, stick to your perspective then.

210's departing footsteps intermingle with Atticus's calm narration, eventually merging into the sound of the wooden door slamming shut.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A House, a Shelter

COL-307906

A House, a Shelter

After 210 left in anger, I heard the shouts of people as the ship set sail.

This debate wasn't planned; it inevitably disrupted the balance, like dropping a pinch of dust on one side of the scale.

Each pinch wasn't very heavy. Even a breath could blow it away. But bit by bit, they still made their impact.

And the balance began to tilt.

Atticus: ...

Atticus: ... The retreat is no place for such arguments. From now on, I should not engage in casual conversations.

I am not fond of talking. Silence is a virtue adhered to by many members of the school.

But in prolonged solitude, I learned to converse with myself.

Language, when devoid of other listeners, diminishes in impact but accelerates self-reflection.

Atticus: I've finished these books. Later, I'll tell the coordinator about the new book list.

I reach out, pulling out a new book from the bottom of the pile.

A scroll, moved by my sleeve, slips from the gap in the book spine and falls to the floor.

It's a poem I know well, one I used to recite silently during those days of reticence.

Atticus: ... "The Golden Verses".

Pythagoras' most famous collection of sayings. Its chronicler is unknown, but the content of the verses is timeless.

Atticus: To think deeply, to restrain oneself, to pursue the treasures of the mind and soul.

Atticus: To respect the gods and the Supreme, to honor the daemons and inhabitants of the elements, to rise above lower worldly natures.

I first heard this poem from Alma.

At that time, she wasn't yet a 6, and she went by her own name.

And I was young, so young that I needed an elder to read me those lengthy verses.

Atticus: Aunt Alma, I don't understand.

Atticus: This part here says: "Fate is like a huge millstone on which mortals roll back and forth, enduring endless suffering."

Atticus: ... Do we really have to be like this? Is fate such a bad thing?

Atticus: Aunt Alma?

Alma: Oh ...

Alma moves the book away from her face, yawning under the gazebo.

Alma: ... Why are you not asleep yet?

Alma: If you ask me, this weather is just perfect for a nap under the grapevines ...

Alma closes her eyes again, ignoring the verses in my hand.

In reality, she is never good with kids.

She takes care of me in place of my mother. For her, it is just another responsibility she has to undertake.

And my mother has more important matters—the responsibilities of a 6.

One day, that responsibility will also belong to me.

Alma: Atticus, why don't you come over here and take a nap?

Alma: Thinking about fate isn't something a child your age should be preoccupied with.

Atticus: But, I want to know—

I am eager to ask my question, but Alma just shakes her head.

Alma: Oh, yes, you're a good child. You've heard much talk from people about 6, fate, truth, the "revelation," and other such grand topics.

Alma: But if you stay fixated on these abstract concepts, the happiness that's right in front of you will slip away.

Alma takes the verses out of my hands and pats me on the back.

Alma: Come, Atticus, lie down here. It's a beautiful day, and these grapes are just ripe.

Alma: I know you're still thinking about the exhortations in "The Golden Verses"—

Alma: "Very few people know how to escape their own misfortune, for they have not yet seen their own fate."

Alma: But this sunlight, the sound of the wind, and these naps are just as much a part of who we are.

Alma: Let's lie here together, savoring these rare, precious moments.

Alma places "The Golden Verses" on her face and drifts back to sleep.

She has always been a humorous and light-hearted person, standing out like a glass bead among pebbles on this island of strict rules.

And I am a solitary and precocious child, prematurely subjected to the burdensome weight of responsibility.

Only around Alma did I feel any relief.

Atticus: ... Lie down, huh?

I hear the birds singing, the wind whispering, the distant sound of waves crashing against the shore.

I have read many profound books, memorized many ancient maxims, and dealt with many complex calculations.

But it was Alma that provided me with "The Golden Verses" with a page filled with bright annotations.

It is a perfect, comfortable warmth, a moment of tranquility that brings no anxiety.

Like the waves that occasionally lap my toes at the edge of the island, gently approaching and then retreating, providing a cool sensation that brings joy to a stroll along the beach.

—She was like that.

So, I leave my sheltered home, tread on the soft sand, and experience the understanding she spoke of.

Experienced what others call "playtime."

The sand is moist, the sea breeze is salty, my clothes feel heavy, and my skin is clammy with droplets of moisture.

The vast sea always by my side, with waves lapping against the shore, yet they never soaked me fully.

A House, a Shelter

COL-307907

Atticus: Alma, I'm back ...

I had spent too much time playing.

So much so that I forgot fate is like a stone rolling down a high mountain, and eventually it rolls over all of us.

6, the original perfect number, a symbol of completeness and harmony.

When it manifests in the soul, the "revelation" from the above is bestowed.

A 6 possesses supreme wisdom, pioneering vision, and just balance. They are perfect in every way, like a beacon leading the faithful forward.

But only afterward did I realize what it truly meant.

Atticus: Alma?

She doesn't respond to my call, or stir at all.

Looking back now, my innate sensitivity as a child picked up on those anomalies long before my own wisdom did.

Atticus: ...

Suddenly feeling fear, I stop asking questions, merely holding my breath and cautiously shifting my feet forward.

Aunt Alma's back is close, and the moonlight casts a gentle glow on her fine, blonde hair.

Atticus: Aunt Alma?

Alma: Hmm? Ah ... look at that, I didn't even notice you were back ...

Waves roll in again, sweeping over my feet.

Atticus: I ... called out to you many times, but you didn't respond ...

Alma: Is that so?

Alma's voice is soft, her hands warm ... turning hotter. She wraps her arms around my shoulders, drawing my stiff body into her embrace.

The sea rises, climbing up to my shins.

Alma: I was sorting my thoughts. Sorry, I didn't hear you at all.

Alma: Until just now, my mind was a mess, but I'm thinking more clearly now. I've figured it out.

She combs my hair, wiping off the sweat I'd built from running, and straightens my collar.

Alma: Poor child, you're all sweaty, and there are rat scratches on the hem of your shirt. You must have run into those little monsters ...

Alma: Don't be afraid, child.

Alma: "Pray to the gods for what you are about to do, and pray that all goes well."

I feel it, the dampness reaching up to my chin.

—Who are you?

A question I find lodged in my throat is choking me so much I can barely breathe.

Atticus: Aunt Alma, has something happened here ... ?

Believer: Alma—and Atticus, come with me—!

The man's shout suddenly rings out.

He just ran past, through the alleys and streets, past the Hall of Apeiron. His sweat-slicked skin shimmers under the moonlight like a soldier bearing bad news, like in the story books of old.

Believer: We need to hurry, faster ... or it'll be too late ... !

Alma: No ... it's already too late.

Alma: The "revelation" has come ... it means she—my sister has returned to the truth.

Alma: The knock of wisdom arrives before me, entering my mind and allowing me to see everything.

Alma pulls the man's hand from my arm.

Her voice is calm, her face sorrowful. She turns her head slightly and hugs me tighter.

Alma: Just, oh, Atticus, my poor child.

Alma: My poor child ...

Alma became 6 that day.

A complete number, a perfect person, and an outstanding leader.

But 6 was not Alma. Not any longer.

Atticus: Let go of me!

I wrench her hand away and run desperately, trying to escape the suffocating tide.

Until the choking waves overwhelm me, and I find myself back on the beach, unconsciously reciting "The Golden Verses."

My fear originates from it, yet when I feel uncertain, I still return here, like a child who can't imagine straying too far from home.

Atticus: ...

Atticus: "Pray to the gods for what you are about to do" ...

Through a blur, the silhouette of the new 6 emerges.

Complete, wise, her words clear and impeccable like the ancient maxims.

Alma: "Pray to the gods for what you are about to do, and pray that all goes well."

Alma: "Once familiar with this practice, you will understand the constitution of both eternal gods and mortal men."

Alma: "You will know the extent of all things, the boundaries of their entirety, and what connects them together."

Alma: "You will see, as you should, that the nature of the universe flows in all things alike."

Alma: "Thus you will not hope for what is beyond your reach, and you will not be deceived."

I can't think any further. My initial doubts are blocking my thoughts.

Atticus: ... "Revelation" ...

Atticus: Is this the "revelation" that falls upon a 6?

The sea completely engulfs my head, the suffocation reminding me ... that I have lost someone dear to me forever.

And this is "the blessing from above."

For a long time afterward, I could not sleep in peace. I would often sneak down to the beach, listening to the waves until exhaustion at last closed my eyes.

In a daze, a voice of wisdom would say—

"Don't fear, child. ' Remember that the grace of the gods is given in the form of disaster, and endure it patiently. Such is fate; do not complain.'"

Atticus: ...

I vaguely realize something, and I open my eyes to see the silent boulder high on the mountain overlooking the island.

One day it will crush me, just as it has crushed Alma.

So, I cover my ears and bend down.

From then on, I no longer gaze at the boulder on the mountain nor look at the teetering bottle on the table.

... Until much later, when I have a brief conversation with a girl named Sophia.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Pebbles

COL-307908

Pebbles

Stories of fighting against fate are often not all that heart-stirring.

In this story, there is no shepherd, no messenger, no Sphinx.

No head is severed by a sword, no one is born or dies because of it.

Nor can it be told to others.

Atticus: What I face is "the revelation" ...

It is an unseen enemy.

It is described as supreme wisdom, the voice from above. It perpetuates in 6s, urging them to fulfill the mission as leaders.

It's not a tangible bottle. I can't lay a soft cloth to catch the pieces of a soul.

But her first words inspire me—not everything needs a complete reason.

—One must do something. Whatever it is, it's better than just waiting.

... So, is it feasible to fight knowledge with knowledge?

Remove the picture book, and the other books in front of me are still more than enough to fill this modest space.

If "the revelation" is the wisdom destined to completely fill a person, perhaps I can do a little preparation work.

It's like filling the bottle with stones beforehand so that it won't be easily knocked over.

Atticus: Hmm, Euclid's "Elements" ...

In school, it's considered the most basic text, but I dare not say I truly understand it. It is in the simplest of readings that the deepest wisdom is found.

This is a suitable beginning.

Everyone has their own soul number. I am not the one chasing Truth across the beach.

210 and 37 are extremely intelligent children. But most importantly, they have a boundless desire for truth. They build ships, make oars, and sail with gusto into the sea, tirelessly navigating the currents, undaunted by the waves crashing against the hull.

While I am the silent reef on the shore, waiting for the day that fate will knock me down, filling the trenches of this seabed.

Can I withstand that transcendent force? Can I overcome its overwhelming will? It seems almost impossible.

Atticus: ... But regardless, I will make my preparations.

I sit at the table talking to myself.

Classical Unities

COL-307909

Classical Unities

I see what lies behind the words.

Knowledge flows from the minds of those who came before to the tips of their pens, then is inked across pages, bound into books, and preserved for the future.

This is much like the fate of 6. only that I inherit wisdom from others in a different way.

When you gaze at it, it no longer has a complete form. "Wisdom" is a name forcibly given — it is actually a collection of the complex thoughts of the human species.

I drink merrily with mountain thieves, I voyage with heroes, I invite the wise to my side and debate with them.

I read from books as if I were peering into the thoughts of someone else's mind.

Gradually holding these thoughts in my palm, I realize that, however complex their curves may be, they only have two ends.

At one end is "life," and at the other is "death."

Because this is the fate of man. We are like hemp on a spindle, a finite collection despite all our variations.

The world is destined for strife, misfortune, and calamity. The good are not always rewarded for their virtues, nor are the wicked always punished for their sins.

In the end, everything just happens, as purposeless as the pebbles washed up on a beach.

Atticus: ...

Atticus: Is this all there is?

That night was darker than usual; even the shimmering sea was engulfed by the inky blackness. I felt the sand under my feet slipping away, and I, in my totality, started to float away with it.

All color faded, and I was suspended in an empty, black space.

That day, Alma wanted to see me. I closed the "Nothingness of Being" and left my room for the first time after a long retreat.

I return to the roofed home and climb up the slope, away from the sea's embrace.

Alma grabs my hand. She's heard of my recent struggles and worries that I am falling into the void of knowledge.

I guess every word before she speaks—6's wisdom, the ancient maxims, the advice of "The Golden Verses"—I've heard them all endlessly.

I don't blame her, this is the 6's duty, her destiny.

I brush her hand away and return to my own battlefield.

Even if knowledge leads to void, I need to use it to confront that unknown "revelation."

210: —!

Someone stops me. It's 210. I hear him speak with intense emotion about "the revelation".

Atticus: The revelation is a curse, my friend.

I shouldn't have answered, for this is not his fate. He always tries to meddle in matters far beyond his abilities, which only brings disaster upon himself and others.

Cautious Daedalus and proud Icarus both fitted themselves with wings and attempted to fly over the sea.

The former landed safely at a low altitude, while the latter flew too close to the sun, only to fall from the sky under its wax-melting heat.

It's not hard to see the one he more closely resembles.

Thirty-seven: ... ?

Someone enters my retreat. It's 37. She's always curious, always puzzling and questioning.

Fortunately, she also always firmly believes she is right.

Atticus: ... Sorry, 37. I can't help you with this right now.

In truth I can answer her; my own questions earlier were as much or more profound than hers.

And perhaps I could offer many wise answers, but they might do her more harm than good.

The sea nymph Thetis dipped her son Achilles in the River Styx, granting him immortality.

To keep her baby from being swept away by the strong current, the mother held onto him by the heel. Her love made Achilles' heel his one fatal weakness.

It's not hard to see where 37's own weaknesses lie. At the very least, I shouldn't reveal them prematurely.

I close the door again and sit in silence.

And who am I? To which fable do I belong?

Yes, I know that too.

—Oedipus went through his struggles and met his prophesied doom. Thus, the perfect tragedy came into being.

Everything is crystal clear.

Atticus: ... Now I know it all.

Atticus: But what do I do next?

TO BE CONTINUED...

Underneath the Sea Level

COL-307910

Underneath the Sea Level

Since the night my mother passed away, I haven't set foot in the cemetery where she is buried.

It's truly unsettling when fate presents itself in such a tangible form.

But then, on a whim, I decided to go there.

It was like receiving a revelation.

Atticus: ... Alma?

She ought to be busy preparing for the voyage, but here she is, standing silently on the grass, like a living tombstone.

When she sees me, she isn't surprised, as if she had already known what fate had planned.

Alma: Atticus, my child, your timing is perfect.

Alma: I know you've always harbored doubts, and our shared bloodline has only added to this divide.

Alma: You've tried to counter the 'revelation' with knowledge, but it only leads you further into confusion. You get lost in a maze of thoughts and fears, unable to find the red thread of escape.

Atticus: ... I've heard this before, Alma.

She smiles, shaking her head, and pulls out a hardcover book.

Alma: I think you're going to need this.

Alma: Good afternoon, child.

I hear her footsteps fade away beyond the trees, like a dewdrop sliding off a leaf.

Lowering my head, I see the name of the book.

Atticus: The Voice From Above.

It's a children's picture book, familiar to every child on the island. It has been endlessly discussed and even argued over. The story is vivid and clear in my mind without even seeing the pages.

Atticus: "A voice from the above spoke to a man, 'An important thing will happen to you.'"

Atticus: Thus, he spends his life waiting for a miracle.

Atticus: Until death arrives, and nothing has happened.

Atticus: "When the man lay sick in bed, he cried up to the voice from above, asking, 'When will all that you have promised finally arrive?'"

Atticus: "The voice from above said, 'I gave you countless opportunities to work miracles, but you missed them all.'"

Atticus: "Because you thought you knew your fate, you took no action. In the end, you achieved nothing."

I used to despise this story because it dressed the will of the heavens as a kind of desirable benefit and said nothing about the cruelty of fate.

But stripping away all misunderstandings, its message is simple: Do not wait; you must take destiny into your own hands.

—This is something I've long known and acted by.

Atticus: ... What else is there in this book that I had missed? That I needed?

Before I realized it, I found I had walked to the beach. And it was already dark.

Underneath the Sea Level

COL-307911

The days that follow are calm.

The believers, seeking truth and knowledge, sail out to explore a world of constantly changing phenomena.

But the ship's return is far later than expected.

Believer I: No ... impossible, they are already well past the maximum deviation possible. They must return today ...

Believer I: As long as they are alive and on the ship, there's no way they cannot be headed back ...

They wait day and night by the coast, eagerly anticipating the return of their leader and the ship.

Soon, they grow increasingly panicked.

Believer II: Hey - look, that's the ship!

Until one person shouts excitedly, jumping high with the joyful news.

Believer I: I knew it, I knew they were alright!

Believer II: I'm so glad–

The ship returns from its voyage along its planned route, with no deviation in angle or speed.

People run to the coast, waiting to welcome new insights from the outside world, believing these unprecedented ideas will illuminate the path of truth.

Sophia: Dad—!

Among them is Atticus's dear friend.

Sophia: —

The "emanation" descends upon them.

Everyone is calling out; everyone is in an uproar. They scream, cry, and fall to the sandy ground.

The ominous noise even reaches the roofed room.

Atticus: ...

Ignoring his trembling fingers, Atticus takes the book and opens it on the table.

Regardless of the worst outcome, this is what he had planned to do.

Atticus: "A voice from the above spoke to a man."

Atticus: An important thing will happen to you.

Atticus: What will it be? The man asked.

Atticus: You will gain wealth, you will gain fame. You will walk in the garden of wisdom and happiness. The voice answered ...

The reading voice stops. His fingers lingering on the page.

At the same time, a geometric shape washes ashore.

It's a beautiful tetrahedron, brilliant with a golden hue like Alma's shining blonde hair when she was in good health.

—The "revelation" has knocked on his door.

Countless ancient knowledge is conveyed through the imprint of the Soul Number 6.

Moral, historical, empirical, abstract, mathematical, humanistic.

This is the crystallization of wisdom passed down from generation to generation by the island's leaders, a glimpse of the mysteries transmitted through the bloodline by those who perceive the truth.

Revelation, knowledge, wisdom —

They surge so tumultuously and vastly that entire lifetimes of achievements and thoughts from mortals are like bottles of water compared to the mighty ocean.

The boulder of fate has rolled down from its peak, and a new 6 is born.

Six: …

The reef remains unchanged. It has been hardened by the erosive force during the long night.

The paused hand gently falls and turns the page.

Six: "Revelation" …

Six: It is just as simple as it is.

THE END

Method of Exhaustion

COL-307912

Atticus: Are you here to collect your sand again today?

Sophia: Yes. The fine sand here is ideal for polishing lenses. My father's eyeglasses are just about ready.

Sophia is a hard-working girl. She is always ready to change, to become a better version of herself.

She knows nothing of her future fate and, therefore, has no fear. Her core is so firm, her steps so sure. It's enviable.

Perhaps that's one of the reasons I asked her that question.

Atticus: … Why do you choose to struggle so much against the path of fate?

I didn't really expect an answer from her; it was just spontaneous curiosity.

We are entirely different people. Even if she gave her reasons, they wouldn't help me, not really.

Because I have exhausted every possibility and sought every line of reasoning.

My question is unsolvable.

Sophia remains silent, wanting to say something but hesitating. She twists the ends of her hair, avoiding my eyes.

Sophia: … I have to do something, anything.

That's a peculiar answer.

Without any reason, any logic, just "doing something."

So, I am left puzzled again.

Sophia: … But preparing for what must come is better than doing nothing at all.

Sophia: Right, the glass bottle—like the one on the table …

She flusteredly tries to give an example, inventing a glass bottle that is bound to break, then surrounding it with a cloth.

This way, even if the bottle still breaks, we can pick up the pieces more easily.

It's a practical explanation—pragmatic and devoid of abstraction. This is her answer to fate, the total opposite of mine.

Atticus: Thank you for the long talk, Sophia.

A new path is carved out between the waters.

TO BE CONTINUED...